

April Fools' Day: Just Joking [B1]

Anche le tradizioni più semplici e divertenti hanno un'origine storica affascinante. In quali circostanze e per quali motivi il 1° aprile è stato considerato il “Pesce d'aprile” in diverse culture?



April [Fools'](#) Day, which occurs on 1 April in many countries around the world, is a day for jokes and [pranks](#), but nobody knows for sure how it started. However, there are several theories of its origins. One theory connects the day to the [joyful](#) ancient Roman festival Hilaria, celebrated on 25 March in honour of Cybele, the Mother of Gods, with games, masquerades, and [mockery](#) to welcome the arrival of spring. Other festivals, such as the two-day Hindu Holi, the Persian Sizdah Bedar, and the Jewish Purim, also focus on joy and fun during spring. However, there is no solid evidence [linking](#) April [Fools'](#) Day to these so-called 'renewal festivals'. A common [trait](#) of these festivals is that during these events, the social order is suspended: servants or children temporarily challenge the authority of masters, parents and teachers. Afterwards, order is reaffirmed and the stability of society is [restored](#).

MEDIEVAL OR RENAISSANCE

Hypotheses about April [Fools'](#) Day also include links to medieval literature, as some see a [glimpse](#) of April [Fools'](#) Day in Geoffrey Chaucer's *The Canterbury Tales* (1392): in one of the stories, a [vain cock](#) is [tricked](#) by a [fox](#), and the event seemingly occurs on 1 April. A very popular theory connects April [Fools'](#) Day to the 16th century, when the Christian world adopted the Gregorian calendar. Before this change, the new year was celebrated around 1 April. When the calendar shifted to make 1 January the start of the year, people who continued to observe it in April were mocked as April fools. The first definite mention of April [Fools'](#) Day comes from a 1561 [Flemish](#) poem that describes a nobleman tricking his servant on 1 April, sending him on [meaningless](#) tasks. By the 17th century, the tradition was so widely [spread](#) that on 1 April serious events were sometimes dated differently to prevent any possible confusion. It seems that the Treaty of Warsaw (1683) had [to be backdated](#) to 31 March!

DIFFERENT TRADITIONS

Different countries developed unique traditions for April [Fools'](#) Day. For instance, in Italy and France people [pin](#) paper fish on others' backs while [shouting](#) "Pesce d'aprile!", or "Poisson d'avril!". The expression is probably linked to fish being plentiful and hungry in the spring, making them easy [to catch](#): the April fish is more [gullible](#) than at other times of the year. In Scotland, the day was known as Taily Day, with reference to a pig's [tail](#), and a "Kick me" sign placed on someone's back became a common prank. In Ireland, people played practical jokes by sending someone to deliver a note that read "Send the fool [further](#)."

WHAT'S SO FUNNY?

Not everyone loves April [Fools'](#) Day, though. Pranks can feel annoying or even mean, especially if they embarrass someone or go too far. Besides, in the age of the internet, April [Fools'](#) jokes sometimes add to the [flood](#) of fake news, leaving people disorientated or [misinformed](#). April Fools' Day has, in fact, [swiftly](#) evolved in recent times, with the rise of social media and mass communication amplifying its [reach](#). What was once a tradition of personal [pranks](#) has now expanded to large-scale jokes, often shared by [media outlets](#) and online platforms, making it a global event where [pranks](#) can go viral.

Glossary

- **gullible** = credulone, boccalone
- **tail** = coda
- **further** = più lontano
- **mockery** = burle
- **fox** = volpe
- **spread** = diffondersi
- **flood** = inondazione
- **misinformed** = disinformata
- **swiftly** = rapidamente
- **media outlets** = mezzi di comunicazione
- **Fools'** = sciocchi, stupidi
- **shouting** = gridare
- **to catch** = catturare
- **reach** = portata
- **pranks** = scherzi
- **joyful** = allegro
- **linking** = collegare
- **vain** = vanitoso
- **Flemish** = fiammingo
- **meaningless** = insensato
- **to be backdated** = retrodatare
- **pin** = attaccare
- **trait** = caratteristica
- **restored** = ristabilire
- **glimpse** = barlume, assaggio
- **cock** = gallo
- **tricked** = ingannare